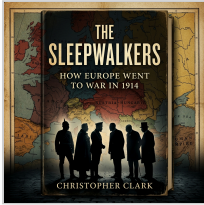


The Great War: Causes & Outbreak - Guided Reading Extract



The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914

By Christopher Clark

"The protagonists of 1914 were sleepwalkers, watchful but unseeing, haunted by dreams, yet blind to the reality of the horror they were about to bring into the world. The Franco-Prussian War had planted a bitter seed of revenge in France, while Bismarck's creation of the German Empire had fundamentally upset the delicate balance of power that had held Europe together."

Comprehension & Inference

1. What metaphor does the author use to describe the European leaders of 1914?

2. According to the extract, what 'bitter seed' was planted by the Franco-Prussian War?

3. How did the creation of the German Empire affect the rest of Europe?



Heart of Darkness

By Joseph Conrad

"The conquest of the earth, which mostly means the taking it away from those who have a different complexion or slightly flatter noses than ourselves, is not a pretty thing when you look into it too much. They grabbed what they could get for the sake of what was to be got. It was just robbery with violence, aggravated murder on a great scale."

Comprehension & Inference

1. According to Conrad, what does the 'conquest of the earth' really involve?

2. How does the author describe the true motivations of the imperialists?

3. Why do you think this text was considered highly controversial when it was published in 1899?



The Riddle of the Sands

By Erskine Childers

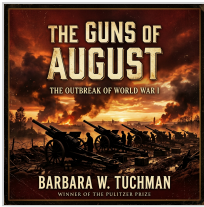
"We were in the presence of a vast, secret, and meticulously organized naval preparation. The German Empire, cramped within its borders, was building a fleet not for defense, but to strike a sudden, paralyzing blow across the North Sea. The Dreadnoughts were merely the visible tip of a spear aimed directly at the heart of England."

Comprehension & Inference

1. What secret threat did the narrator believe they had discovered?

2. According to the extract, why was the German Empire building its fleet?

3. How would reading a popular thriller like this have affected the British public's attitude toward Germany?



The Guns of August

By Barbara W. Tuchman

"The alliances were ostensibly defensive, but in reality, they operated as tripwires. The nations of Europe were locked into a rigid, inflexible machine. When the first shot was fired in the Balkans, it was as if a massive, terrible clockwork mechanism had been set in motion. Mobilization meant war, and once the trains started rolling, no diplomat could stop them."

Comprehension & Inference

1. Why does the author describe the defensive alliances as 'tripwires'?

2. What metaphor is used to describe the outbreak of the war?

3. According to the text, why were the diplomats unable to stop the war once it started?



All Quiet on the Western Front

By Erich Maria Remarque

"During drill-time Kantorek gave us long lectures until the whole of our class went, under his shepherding, to the District Commandant and volunteered. I can see him now, as he used to glare at us through his spectacles and say in a moving voice: 'Won't you join up, Comrades?' ... We were all at once terribly earnest. No one had the vaguest idea what we were in for."

Comprehension & Inference

1. Who was Kantorek, and what did he persuade the entire class to do?

2. How did the adults, like teachers, use the idea of 'duty' or 'comradeship' to pressure young men?

3. How does this extract help explain the incredible surge of Nationalism and volunteering at the outbreak of the war?
